



The whole picture: looking, again, at left-wing authoritarianism and its associations with dark personality traits

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Introduction

In 2025, The Telegraph published an article titled “Greta Thunberg’s narcissism has escalated to terrifying levels”, portraying the activist’s planned travel to Gaza and example of “hollow virtue” and warning that such activism is “dangerous” (O’Neill, 2025). Public claims that political activism reflects narcissistic or sinister motives highlight widespread interest in the psychological roots of political attitudes, mirrored in media attention to research on the Dark Triad and left-wing authoritarianism (LWA) (Mitchell, 2023). Specifically, research on the dark-ego-vehicle principle (DEVP) proposes that “individuals with dark personalities – such as high narcissistic and psychopathic traits – are attracted to certain ideologies and forms of political activism” (Krispenz & Bertrams, 2024, p. 2726).

Whilst questioning others’ underlying motives for behavior is fundamental to social perception, suspecting ulterior motives can reduce the perceived value of the behavior (Fein, 1996; Marchand & Vonk, 2005) and can foster continued distrust independent of the actual plausibility of “darker” motives (Main et al., 2007). Moreover, humans show biases when judging others’ moral motives, leading, for example, to resentment when a behavior is seen as threatening to one’s moral self-view (Monin et al., 2008). Thus, while questioning motives is natural, observers are not neutral judges, underscoring the importance of psychological research in clarifying links between activism and potentially ulterior motives.

Previous research on personality, authoritarianism, and intergroup attitudes showed inconsistent results regarding relationships among narcissism, psychopathy, and (right-wing) authoritarianism (Hodson et al., 2009; Stathi et al., 2021; Zeigler-Hill et al., 2020). One possible reason is a theoretical inconsistency: authoritarianism—regardless of political direction—entails submission to ingroup norms and established authority (Duckitt, 1989; Kessler & Cohrs, 2008; Stellmacher & Petzel, 2005), whereas narcissism reflects grandiosity, entitlement, and a dominant, status-seeking orientation (Jones & Paulhus, 2014), which appears at odds with norm-bound submission. The studies cited above largely reconcile this tension indirectly by linking narcissism to competitive social worldviews and social dominance orientation, which in turn predict authoritarian and hierarchical attitudes (Hodson et al., 2009; Stathi et al., 2021; Zeigler-Hill et al., 2020). Thus, narcissism may align more with the dominance and hierarchy-enhancing components of authoritarianism than with norm-submissive conformity per se.

Scholarly interest in LWA has intensified amid growing concern about political polarization and rising partisan hostility (Conway et al., 2018; Costello et al., 2022; Ditto et al., 2019). LWA captures a form of authoritarianism in the “service of left-wing outcomes” (Costello et al., 2022, p. 136), characterized by three dimensions: anti-hierarchical aggression, anticonventionalism, and top-down censorship (see Table 1 for descriptions). In their two-study paper, Krispenz and Bertrams (2024) investigated the associations between narcissism and the three LWA subdimensions, expecting “individuals with higher levels of LWA to report higher levels of narcissism” (p. 2716). They concluded that “results of both studies are in line with this prediction” (p. 2726), based on significant positive associations between the anti-hierarchical aggression dimension (LWA-AHA) and antagonistic narcissism in Study 1 and LWA-AHA and psychopathy in Study 2. However, Study 1 found no robust associations between narcissism and overall LWA, or between the anticonventionalism (LWA-AC) and top-down censorship (LWA-TDC)

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Table 1 Overview of the key constructs/variables

Construct	Description	Measurement / Example items	Measure (Reference)
LWA: Anti-Hierarchical Aggression (LWA-AHA)	The motivation to use aggression and force to dismantle existing hierarchies and power relations	<i>"The rich should be stripped of their belongings and status."</i> <i>"If I could remake society, I would put people who currently have the most privilege at the very bottom."</i>	Left-Wing Authoritarian Index (LWAI; Costello et al., 2022)
LWA: Anticonventionalism (LWA-AC)	Moral absolutism toward progressive values, including intolerance of conservatives, and a desire for ideological conformity	<i>"Anyone who opposes gay marriage must be homophobic."</i> <i>"The 'old-fashioned ways' and 'old-fashioned values' need to be abolished."</i>	
LWA: Top-Down Censorship (LWA-TDC)	The endorsement of using authority (e.g., governmental limitations) as a means of regulating the expression of right-wing expression	<i>"University authorities are right to ban hateful speech from campus."</i> <i>"I should have the right not to be exposed to offensive views."</i>	
Narcissism	A trait characterized by grandiosity, entitlement, dominance, and a strong need for admiration and status.	<i>"People see me as a natural leader."</i> <i>"I know that I am special because everyone keeps telling me so."</i> <i>"I insist on getting the respect that I deserve."</i>	Short Dark Triad (SD3; Jones & Paulhus, 2014)
Psychopathy	A trait characterized by callousness, impulsivity, low empathy, and a propensity toward antisocial and risk-taking behavior.	<i>"I like to get revenge on authorities."</i> <i>"It's true that I can be mean to others."</i> <i>"People who mess with me always regret it."</i>	
Machiavellianism	A trait characterized by strategic manipulation, cynicism about human nature, and a calculated focus on long-term self-interest.	<i>"It's not wise to tell your secrets."</i> <i>"I like to use clever manipulation to get my way."</i> <i>"Whatever it takes, you must get the important people on your side."</i>	
Social Justice Commitment	Reflects individuals' intention, planning, perceived feasibility, and personal commitment to engage in social justice activities in the future.	<i>"In the future, I intent to engage in social justice activities"</i> <i>"I am fully committed to engaging in social justice activities."</i> <i>"I have a plan of action for ways I will remain or become involved in social justice activities over the next year."</i>	Social Issues Questionnaire (SIQ; Miller et al., 2009)
Virtue Signaling	The degree to which moral self-presentation in public diverges from privately endorsed moral values.	Virtue signaling was operationalized as the residual of moral identity symbolization after controlling for moral identity internalization using the Moral Identity Scale (Aquino & Reed, 2002), thereby capturing public moral self-expression independent of internalized moral values.	Krispenz and Bertrams (2024)

Note: LWA =Left-wing authoritarianism

subdimensions, whilst Study 2 focused solely on anti-hierarchical aggression as the dependent variable, despite measuring all three components of LWA (top-down censorship, anticonventionalism, and anti-hierarchical aggression).

Thus, questions remain about the potentially more complex links between narcissism, the broader Dark Triad, and the full LWA construct. Furthermore, the analytical approach in the original paper, linear regressions, prevented modeling the complex relationships between the sub-facets of LWA and the Dark Triad. In this paper, we thus aim to shed further light on the associations between LWA and Dark Triad traits by reanalyzing the original Study 2 dataset by Krispenz and

Bertrams (2024). Specifically, we model the relationships between LWA and the three Dark Triad traits using an analytical approach that accounts for all relationships simultaneously, including those among the Dark Triad traits and LWA subdimensions.

Method

We used the original data ($N=375$) from Study 2 (Krispenz & Bertrams, 2024), collected by the original authors via an online survey platform in 2022. The sample was

US-based, 50.7% female, and 53% reported an affiliation with the Democratic party (see the original publication for further details)¹. The measures are described in the original publication (Krispenz & Bertrams, 2024) and include the Short Dark Triad (Jones & Paulhus, 2014) to assess narcissism, psychopathy, and Machiavellianism, and the LWAI (Costello et al., 2022) to assess left-wing authoritarianism. A description of all variables and measures is presented in Table 1.

Results

We used lavaan Version 0.6-20.2278 (Rosseel, 2012) for all analyses (see SOM 1 for the R script). Before testing the relationships, we conducted a confirmatory factor analysis with narcissism, psychopathy, and Machiavellianism as latent variables loading on their respective measurement items. We also specified a higher-order factor, Dark Triad, with loadings on these three factors. We specified the latent variables for the LWA subscales anti-hierarchical aggression, top-down censorship, and anticonventionalism accordingly, such that they were also affected by a higher-order factor (LWA). The model also included a latent variable for social justice and a single-item factor for virtue. The model fitted acceptably well, $X^2(2403) = 5504.84$, RMSEA = 0.055, 95% CI = 0.053; 0.057, SRMR = 0.082, GFI = 0.68, TLI = 0.80 (see SOM 1 for details).

For our subsequent investigations of relationships between LWA and (subdimensions) of the Dark Triad, we employ structural equation modeling with the structural-after-measurement-approach (SAM). This approach (Rosseel & Loh, 2024) separates the estimation of the measurement and structural models into two steps. Compared with standard structural equation modeling, the SAM approach reduces model estimation complexity and increases stability, particularly in small samples (Rosseel & Loh, 2024). SAM models allow us to model the relationships among all variables of interest such that the resulting complex models with latent variables can still be fitted on the given sample size.

We first fitted a SAM model regressing the latent variable left-wing-authoritarianism on the latent Dark Triad variable, controlling for virtue signaling, social justice commitment, age, and gender. In line with prior findings, the Dark Triad was positively associated with left-wing authoritarianism, $b = 0.34$, $p = .018$, $\beta = 0.13$ (see SOM1 for details).

To investigate the relationship between the individual subdimensions of the Dark Triad on left-wing authoritarianism, we fitted a second SAM model without a higher-order factor for the Dark Triad that regressed the latent variable left-wing authoritarianism (LWA) on the latent variables narcissism, psychopathy, and Machiavellianism, controlling for age, gender, virtue signaling, and social justice commitment, see Fig. 1. It revealed a positive association between psychopathy and LWA, $b = 0.43$, $p = .007$, $\beta = 0.32$, and a negative association between narcissism and LWA, $b = -0.28$, $p = .009$, $\beta = -0.20$. The relationship between Machiavellianism and LWA was not significant, $b = -0.15$, $p = .54$, $\beta = -0.06$. Finally, we fitted a third SAM model regressing the three subdimensions of LWA on the three subdimensions of the Dark Triad (SOM1). Anti-hierarchical aggression was negatively related to narcissism, $b = -0.31$, $p = .041$, and positively related to psychopathy, $b = 0.91$, $p < .001$, and not related to Machiavellianism. The same pattern emerged for anticonventionalism, with $b = -0.43$, $p = .005$ (narcissism) and $b = 0.56$, $p = .008$ (psychopathy). Top-down censorship was not related to any of the three Dark Triad traits, and Machiavellianism was not significantly associated with the LWA subdimensions.

Discussion

We aimed to extend Krispenz and Bertram's (2024) investigation of the relationship between narcissism and left-wing authoritarianism. Using their Study 2 dataset, our findings contradict the conclusion that narcissism is positively related to left-wing authoritarianism (LWA). Analyzing their data with a structural equation model that included the Dark Triad dimensions (narcissism, psychopathy, and Machiavellianism) as predictors of LWA, results showed the opposite: Narcissism was, in fact, negatively related to LWA and to the anti-hierarchical aggression and anticonventionalism subdimensions, and unrelated to top-down censorship. Thus, the original author's statement that "individuals with dark personalities – such as high narcissistic and psychopathic traits – are attracted to certain ideologies and forms of political activism" (p. 2726) is too broad: For narcissism, the *opposite* is the case. Finally, in our analyses, social justice commitment was positively associated with the LWA subscales and full scale.

Integrating our findings with the insights from Studies 1 and 2 of the original paper, we conclude that the associations between LWA and narcissism, but also the Dark Triad traits in general, are more complex than discussed in the original paper. Most importantly, our analysis contradicts the conclusion that LWA is positively associated with narcissism – this result appears to be a methodological artifact

¹ The original publication reports $N = 377$ in the demographics, but regression models were based on a smaller sample. This discrepancy likely reflects the exclusion of two participants who indicated their gender as "other." For consistency with the original analyses, we likewise excluded these participants.

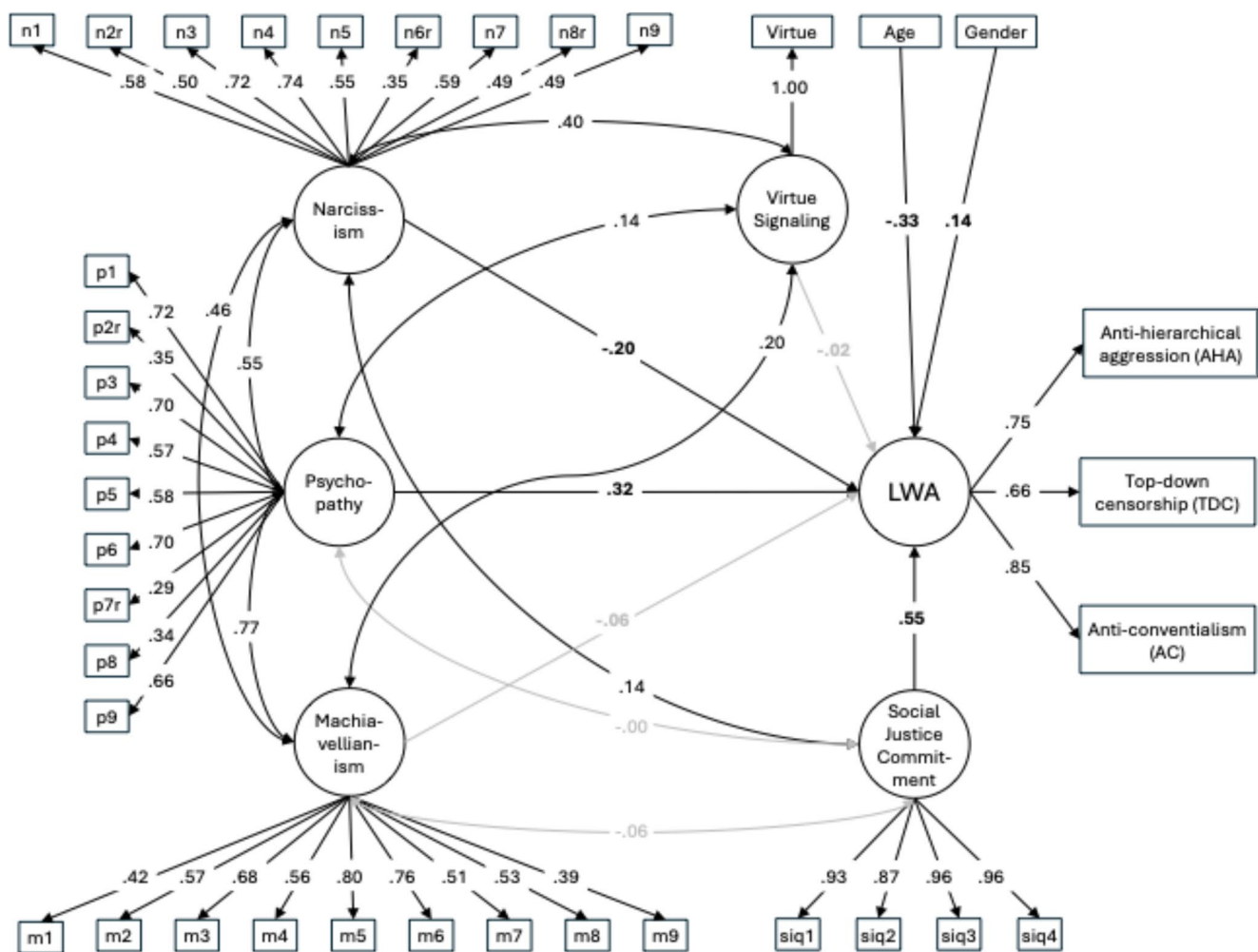


Fig. 1 Results of the Structural-After-Measurement (SAM) structural equation model regressing Left-Wing Authoritarianism (LWA) on the subdimensions of the dark triad and covariates. *Note.* Structural-After-Measurement (SAM) structural equation model regressing left-wing authoritarianism (LWA) on the subdimensions of the Dark Triad and

control variables using the original Study 2 data from Krispenz and Bertrams (2024), $N=375$. Gender is coded as 0 = male and 1 = female. Numbers represent standardized path coefficients. Coefficients with $p > .05$ are greyed out

stemming from the use of a limited set of constructs in standard regression models that cannot account for relationships among the independent variables. Our analyses account for indirect effects and shared variance among predictors, potentially altering the direct relationship between narcissism and LWA. In sum, our results show that the positive overall relationship between LWA and the Dark Triad is solely driven by the underlying positive relationship between psychopathy on the one side, and anti-hierarchical aggression and anticonventionalism on the other. Thus, the findings prohibit interpreting Study 2 in Krispenz and Bertrams (2024) as supporting a broad dark-ego-vehicle principle stating that individuals with dark personalities are attracted to left-wing ideology and activism.

Our analysis also showed that although narcissism and psychopathy are positively related (see Fig. 1), they have

opposed relationships with LWA. In the absence of a finding regarding narcissism and LWA in the original paper (Krispenz & Bertrams, 2024), the authors concluded that the positive association between psychopathy and anti-hierarchical aggression is sufficient to support the dark-ego-vehicle principle, arguing that people with high narcissism and high psychopathy share several attributes (cf. Jones & Palhus, 2014). However, the overall level of psychopathy in the sample was low ($M=1.96$, $SD=0.62$, SOM2), suggesting that the association is likely driven by small score differences and should be interpreted with caution. Future research, therefore, needs to examine whether this effect generalizes to samples with broader distributions of psychopathy values.

More attention should also be given to how items in the psychopathy scale are phrased. For example, the reversed items “I avoid dangerous situations” and “I have never

gotten into trouble with the law” (Jones & Paulhus, 2014) may capture behaviors related to activism (e.g., protesting) rather than psychopathic traits, potentially resulting in circular reasoning. Similarly, the item “I enjoy having sex with people I hardly know” might reflect anticonventionalism, as left-wing attitudes are often linked to more permissive sexual behavior (Brody et al., 1996).

Contrary to the original paper’s results, we did not find evidence that LWA is generally negatively related to prosociality or positively associated with self-presentation, a conclusion reached by researchers citing the original study (Hart et al., 2024). Instead, as in the original study, we found that social justice commitment was consistently and positively associated with LWA. Thus, the results contradict the conclusion of the original paper that “some political activists on the left side of the political spectrum do not actually strive for social justice (. . .), but rather endorse or express violence for the satisfaction of their own ego-focused, sometimes even antisocial, needs” (Krispenz & Bertrams, 2024, p. 2726). Although we did find a positive association of virtue signaling with top-down censorship, the subdimension characterized by a preference to use authority to “bar offensive and intolerant speech” (Costello et al., 2022, p. 145), the findings indicated that commitment to social justice and equality is connected to higher levels of LWA. Although this does not mean that there are no left-wing individuals driven by selfish motives, our reanalysis does not support a systematic relationship between such motives and LWA.

In sum, the findings do not, at this point, support the assumption that narcissistic individuals are attracted to left-wing authoritarianism to satisfy ego-focused needs rather than being driven by a social justice commitment. Our analysis underscores the necessity of greater theoretical differentiation and further empirical investigation. While ego-focused needs may contribute to progressive behaviors, they are not inherently linked to left-wing authoritarianism. Accordingly, a comprehensive understanding of (progressive) political behavior requires going beyond a unidimensional focus on authoritarianism.

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Data availability The online supplementary material, including the R-Script, can be accessed via <https://osf.io/7ktp3/overview>.

Declarations

Ethical approval & informed consent This study is a secondary analysis of existing, de-identified data. The original study received ethical approval from the human research ethics committee of the University of Bern (#2022-05-00006) and acquired informed consent from the participants. No additional ethical approval was required for the present analysis.

Conflict of interest The authors have no relevant financial or non-financial interests to disclose.

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